

listen for motor noise while doing so (in the video you shot). Check to see if the camera is hunting for focus (if it allows you to focus in video mode) and also look for noise and see if it is acceptable to you. Remember that most point-n-shoots will be noisy indoors so don't expect miracles.

4. Try out all the functions on the camera, see if you're comfortable with them and whether the camera is comfortable to hold. If you want a pocket camera, don't get tempted by massive zooms and actually check if the camera is pocket-friendly.
5. Inspect the quality of the flaps and hinges, press the buttons, twiddle with the dials; make sure they are seated properly and are not squeaking, also ensure that there is no play in dials and levers and that the settings/scene mode dials lock precisely into place.

Ask

Ask about bundled accessories and freebies. Many stores will give you goodies like a mini tripod or camera bag and/or scratch guard. These can easily be worth up to ₹1,000 or more depending on the quality. You can do the opposite as well; sacrifice the freebies for a discount if you don't need them. Stores such as Reliance Digital and Croma will allow you to do that if you're persuasive enough.



Unless you're an audio enthusiast or audiophile most of your audio purchases will happen as impulse buys. Whether it's an iPod dock that catches your eye at an electronics store or a bundled home theater system that you get as a freebie with your HDTV purchase, the story is the same. When faced with such a situation how do you decide if what you're getting is the best possible product? Well, read on as we brush up on some of the basics and show you how to test that particular piece of audio equipment on the spot.

Research

1. Knowing a few things before hand is always good. For a long time (until consumers smartened up) the trend was to display power rating of speakers in PMPO. In fact for bundled home theaters it still is. Don't go by this figure as it's highly exaggerated. Instead go by the RMS rating. A speaker system with an RMS value of 80 watts or more should be loud enough for a mid-sized room.
2. At most electronics shops, the audio that they play for you may not present an accurate picture your preferences. Take sample tracks with you. But which tracks? Take your favourite music along (if it happens to be Death-metal though, you may have a problem). Ensure that the tracks are high bit rate – at least 320 kbps. This will give you an idea of whether the speakers sound good for your genre of choice. However this is still not good-enough to know whether the speakers play back all frequency ranges properly. For this download sweeps and different frequency tones. One such source is NuForce (<http://dgit.in/P8P2Sa>) and of course there are others (<http://dgit.in/RJdCOy>). Carry these in a pen drive fully uncompressed or in different file formats, or better yet, burn a .CDA album.
3. If you're buying a home theater you should download 5.1 / 7.1 trailers of movies such as *Transformers* or *Battle-ship*. These will have extremely low frequency sounds that give you the whole shake and rumble experience.



A shrine for your iPod

Observe

1. First and foremost when you start demoing any audio equipment go into the settings and disable any DSP effects and other sound enhancements. When comparing two music systems often you will find that effects are turned on for one system and off for the other. Very conveniently, they'll be turned off for the system which makes lesser margins for the dealer.
2. If you're in the market for an iPod dock, be sure to check out all the connectivity options. A standard 3.5 mm line in is a must. If you're planning to connect an iPad check its compatibility. Often the docking pin is compatible but the iPad doesn't fit because the pin is in a depressed slot which is only long enough to fit an iPod.



Wouldn't you want to blow the roof off with these?

3. If you're picking up headphones, whether in-ears, over the ear supra-aural or surrounding the ear circumaurals, some of the things to check include fit, comfort, and isolation. If they don't block out ambient noise in a mall, they're not going to block the noise on your daily train commute.
4. Most audio equipment is littered with certifications. In fact, we won't be too surprised to find Dolby Digital on a vacuum cleaner too in the near future. Of these only some are relevant. THX for instance will give you a better performance for movie audio.

Ask

1. There's not really much you can ask when buying audio gear. One of the things however is warranty like all other categories.
2. Do ask the sales person to co-operate with your antics. For instance when you